

Shaping Inspirational Offices for an Aspirational Gen Z



Neetish Sarda
Founder and Managing Director, Smartworks

India's workforce is getting younger, more vocal, and far less tolerant of workplaces that feel dated or transactional.

For Neetish Sarda, Founder and Managing Director of Smartworks, this shift was visible long before Gen Z became a boardroom talking point.

"Gen Z isn't entering the workforce quietly," Sarda says. "They arrive with expectations, flexibility, speed, and environments that don't feel inherited from another era."

Sarda, who launched Smartworks in his twenties has since built it into India's largest managed campus platform, believed early on that the next generation would judge offices the same way they judge products, on ease of use, experience, and relevance. That conviction shaped how he thought about offices. Sarda approached workplaces as operating infrastructure, spaces that should evolve as quickly as businesses and people do.

"At one point, permanence was mistaken for stability," he says. "But businesses don't operate in fixed cycles anymore. Offices have to adapt just as fast as teams, markets, and technology do."

This thinking closely mirrors how Gen Z approaches work. Access matters more than ownership. Experience outweighs hierarchy. Choice is valued over rigidity. The result is a workplace philosophy built around energy and engagement.

Smartworks' fully managed spaces incorporate social and recreational elements such as cricket pitches, basketball courts, amphitheatres, gyms, cafés, smart convenience stores, sleeping pods, and informal collaboration zones. These amenities reflect a belief that productivity is sustained when people are mentally refreshed, socially connected, and physically comfortable.

"Offices shouldn't drain people by mid-day," Sarda notes. "If employees are spending most of their waking hours at work, the environment has to recharge them, not exhaust them."

Another dimension of Sarda's thinking has been proximity to talent. As workforces spread across cities and neighbourhoods, he anticipated the rise of hub-and-spoke models that allow enterprises to be closer to where people live, without fragmenting operations.

"Talent doesn't want to travel hours for access anymore," he says. "Enterprises have to go where talent is and make it easy for people to engage with work."

That belief has shaped Smartworks' expansion across both Tier-1 and Tier-2 markets. Today, it operates across 13 cities including Bengaluru, Mumbai, Pune, Hyderabad, Chennai, Delhi-NCR, Kochi and Coimbatore. The objective, Sarda says, is not just scale, but consistency, enabling enterprises to deploy teams across locations while maintaining a standardised workplace experience.

Technology forms the final layer of this vision. Digital-native employees expect seamless, app-led experiences everywhere. Sarda pushed for offices that function the same way, from access and service requests to analytics and engagement, allowing the workplace to fade into the background and let work take centre stage.

"For younger employees, the best technology is invisible," he explains. "If the office works intuitively,

people focus on their work, not on navigating systems."

Under Sarda's leadership, Smartworks has positioned itself as a platform that designs, builds and manages offices, delivering custom layouts tailored to enterprise needs, with workspaces that reflect each organisation's brand, culture and way of working. The company has a total area under management of approximately 14 million sq. ft. across 61 centres in India and Singapore, and was listed on India's stock exchanges in July 2025.

"As India's workforce becomes younger and more global, the competitiveness of our economy will increasingly depend on how quickly enterprises can deploy talent," he says, adding, "Flexible, managed infrastructure is becoming as critical to growth as digital or physical connectivity."

Sarda's vision reflects a broader shift underway in India Inc, a move away from offices as static spaces toward environments that actively shape how the next generation builds, collaborates, and grows.

Smartworks today serves over 760 clients. Its diverse clientele includes organisations such as Google, Xoriant, Discovery, Bridgestone, EY, Groww and others that operate at scale and expect consistency across cities.



Smartworks is India's largest Managed Campus Platform. It provides fully managed offices for enterprises and GCCs across India and Singapore in 60 days, enabling fast city entry and multi-city scale without the complexity of traditional leasing or fit-outs.